

When the smoke clears

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POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By GERARDO FORTUNA CIAO T

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CIAO THERE. Gerardo Fortuna back in your inbox, enjoying this hot summer's increasingly strange mix of storylines — like Italian football's coaching saga becoming entangled with Russian influence in Europe.

In today's Playbook:

- Volodymyr Zelenskyy visits Washington amid signs MAGA is warming to Ukraine.
- Friedrich Merz is set to put the hard word on Ireland to slash the proposed MFF.
- Faces in the crowd: Hadja Lahbib, Zombor Berezvai, Volodymyr Zelenskyy, Anna-Kaisa Itkonen, Kurt Volker, Micheál Martin, Laura Loomer, Grégory Allione, Alexis Tsipras, John Thune, Lindsey Graham, Margaritis Schinas, Tim Pool, Zbigniew Ziobro, Mateusz Morawiecki and many more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Ian discuss why the EU's emergency response system is under growing pressure as wildfires spread through Europe.

DRIVING THE DAY

EXCLUSIVE — AFTER THE FIRES: The European Commission will consider whether the wildfires causing so much devastation in southern Europe mean it needs to bring in extra measures to tackle such crises.

It won't have a big rethink just yet — first comes the literal firefighting. "Our immediate priority is supporting efforts to save lives and bring the fires under control as quickly as possible," Crisis Management Commissioner Hadja Lahbib told Playbook.

But once the emergency phase ends, "as we always do, we will carefully assess our overall response to this crisis," Lahbib said. The Commission will draw lessons from this summer and consider whether "further measures or initiatives are needed." She added: "Our policies evolve continuously based on experience."

What can Brussels do? The EU executive doesn't have many powers in this area — firefighting remains a national responsibility. The Commission steps in when capitals request help through the Union Civil Protection Mechanism and its strategic reserve tool, rescEU , which is coming under pressure as several countries ask for aircraft at the same time.

Still waiting for the planes: For now, Europe's firefighting fleet remains largely rented. This summer, rescEU has access to 22 firefighting aircraft and five helicopters, provided by member countries. The Commission is getting its own permanent fleet of 12 Canadairs and five helicopters — although deliveries will run until 2030 because manufacturers can't build them fast enough, an EU official said.

What's happening: France and Spain are battling what the EU describes as an "exceptionally severe" wildfire season. Authorities are in a race against time before temperatures rise again in the middle of the week. In the two countries more than 300,000 people have been evacuated .

Future plan: At the moment, the most concrete idea for tackling such emergencies is the Commission's guidelines to national governments on integrated wildfire risk management — a non-binding roadmap on prevention, land management and coordination — along with a gradual strengthening of rescEU, Commission spokesperson Anna-Kaisa Itkonen told Playbook.

The budget hope: "The next MFF isn't agreed yet, so there might be adjustments," Itkonen pointed out. As part of a compromise text designed to get a deal on the EU's next seven-year budget, Cyprus, which held the six-month presidency of the Council in the first half of this year, earmarked €9.73 billion for the Union Civil Protection Mechanism.

The European Parliament wants to go further: French liberal MEP Grégory Allione — a firefighter since the age of 17 — told Playbook the Parliament is pushing for €12 billion , arguing Europe needs not only more EU-made firefighting equipment, but also more people on the ground, including through an EU directive on citizen engagement.

The context: The EU's permanent firefighting fleet currently under construction was funded with just €600 million.

Capacity isn't everything: More planes alone won't solve the problem, a second EU official said. "You can buy 24 Canadairs. You can buy 50. It will never be enough."

READ MORE: The largest wildfire in Spanish history risks becoming a political liability for the center-right People's Party ahead of next year's general election, as its regional governments face accusations that they failed to prepare adequately for the disaster.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked how the wildfires are affecting you. Whatsapp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

BIG AND BREAKING

EXTRADITION REQUEST: Poland has formally asked the U.S. to arrest and extradite former Justice Minister Zbigniew Ziobro over allegations ranging from abuse of power to spying on political opponents.

POLISH PIS PURGE: The leadership of Law and Justice (PiS) is set to decide the fate of party defectors after former Prime Minister Mateusz Morawiecki's dramatic split on Friday, in which he reportedly walked out the door with 40 MPs and three MEPs. One option on the table: stripping the rebels of their party membership, Polish media report .

MIDDLE EAST LATEST: Donald Trump told reporters aboard Air Force One last night the U.S. is having “good talks” with Iran about ending their conflict, but will resume airstrikes if it doesn’t get a deal. The pause in fighting was put to the test on Monday, with Saudi Arabia, Jordan and Iraq reporting drone attacks , per Reuters.

THE 6G RACE IS ON: Washington is rallying more than 20 allies — including Germany, the U.K. and Japan — to coordinate the next generation of telecoms technology and keep China from dominating 6G.

FRIENDS IN HIGH PLACES: Romania’s Trump-aligned nationalist George Simion says Brussels is intent on destroying Europe’s economy ... and that God is behind his Alliance for the Union of Romanians party.

MAGA AND UKRAINE

MR. ZELENSKY GOES TO WASHINGTON: Volodymyr Zelenskyy is in the U.S. capital today to attend Lindsey Graham’s funeral and meet Donald Trump. His visit comes as some in the MAGA universe seem to be learning to love Kyiv , Zoya Sheftalovich reports.

Far-right activist Laura Loomer, who has in the past amplified Russian narratives, visited Kyiv last week, met Zelenskyy and said she had been “bamboozled by Russian propaganda.” Podcaster Tim Pool, another former critic of Ukraine, said this week that Kyiv was “fighting for its very existence against an evil dictator.”

Even Vice President JD Vance, among Zelenskyy’s top U.S. antagonists, earlier this month softened his tone , praising Ukraine’s defensive strategy and saying Russia’s offensive capabilities are “getting close to zero.”

“There is something happening there,” Trump’s former special representative for Ukraine negotiations Kurt Volker told Zoya. Trump’s declaration at this month’s NATO summit that he had a “good relationship” with Zelenskyy — alongside his backing for Ukrainian production of Patriot interceptors — was “a signal to the MAGA world that it’s OK to support Ukraine,” Volker said.

Note of caution: The new mood music doesn’t amount to a full MAGA embrace of Kyiv and if Zelenskyy wants to get the anti-interventionist wing of the Republican Party on his side, he’ll have a lot more convincing to do during his time in the U.S. Some close to the White House also question the sincerity of Loomer’s about-face.

Sanctions test: MAGA’s apparent evolving stance will face an immediate test in the U.S. Senate, where lawmakers are considering Graham’s stalled Russia sanctions bill. Senate Majority Leader John Thune wants a vote before the August recess, but Trump’s push to include Iran measures has complicated negotiations.

Backing a winner: Ukrainian officials believe Trump is responding to results on the battlefield, where Russia is losing troops, money and momentum, and Ukraine looks increasingly like a winner. Volker appears to agree: “Trump sees that Putin is losing, and he sees that Zelenskyy has actually pulled this all together and is winning.”

DUBLIN, WE HAVE A PROBLEM

A MESSAGE FROM MERZ: German Chancellor Friedrich Merz is heading to Ireland today with a warning: If the Irish presidency of the EU Council doesn't produce a substantially cheaper blueprint for the EU's next seven-year budget, hopes of reaching a deal this year could be dashed.

Cut it down: Merz will use his three-hour visit with Irish Prime Minister Micheál Martin to press Ireland — which in the second half of 2026 chairs negotiations among EU governments — to make far deeper cuts to the European Commission's nearly €2 trillion proposal, my Berlin Playbook colleague Hans von der Burchard reports. Cyprus, which held the presidency in the previous six months, made only modest changes.

Why Germany matters: As the EU's largest net contributor, Berlin's backing is essential. Merz believes that only a considerably smaller package can create a "landing zone" acceptable to Germany and other budget-conscious capitals, according to a European diplomat familiar with his position, granted anonymity to discuss the confidential plans.

The clock is ticking: Merz will warn that failure to strike an agreement this year could push the negotiations deep into 2027 — when elections in France, Italy, Spain and Poland risk further complicating talks.

No new-tax enthusiasm: The pair will also discuss proposals for new sources of EU revenue. Berlin doubts measures such as a digital levy are politically viable and remains hostile to the Commission's proposed charge on large companies.

Why bother? Brussels is considering exempting loss-making and smaller firms, but the diplomat noted that would also reduce the money raised. "Is it worth the trouble?" the diplomat asked, echoing Merz's argument that the levy would undermine European competitiveness.

7 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

HUNGARIAN WHISTLEBLOWER FIGHTS BACK: Zombor Berezvai, the former chief economist at Hungary's competition authority, accused Viktor Orbán's government of political interference — and was promptly fired. Berezvai is now challenging his dismissal in court under the EU Whistleblowing Directive. More in Morning Fair Play (for subscribers).

ROMANIA'S EXHIBIT A: Bucharest summoned Russia's ambassador to protest against violations of its airspace over the weekend — and showed him fragments of drones that were shot down in Romanian territory.

ALL ABOARD: Steffen Bilger is set to become Germany's next transport minister, inheriting the task of dragging its aging infrastructure into the 21st century. More in Morning Mobility (for subscribers).

FOREIGN POLICY DEBUT: Britain's new PM Andy Burnham welcomed Volodymyr Zelenskyy yesterday for his first meeting with a foreign leader, and promised a "close partnership" with Kyiv.

SCOOP — EU'S 2026 HEALTH SPENDING: What's in the European Commission's draft EU4Health work program? Read it in Morning Health (for subscribers).

THE AI ACT GETS SOME BITE: Sunday's second anniversary of the AI Act is more than symbolic. It marks the moment Brussels' AI Office gets sweeping new powers to scrutinize the world's most advanced AI models — and fine companies that don't play ball.

TURNBERRY MATH: The U.S. trade deficit with Europe narrowed in the first half of 2026, with exports to Europe growing faster than imports, led by energy and industrial goods. More in Morning Trade (for subscribers).

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny. High of 29C.

BRUSSELS IS A WASTELAND: Not everyone is on a beach sipping a piña colada right now. Playbook is using the summer break to clear out its trash. But where do you go in Brussels if you have a load of literal junk to get rid of?

The region has six Recyparks — recycling centers ... or dumps, to you and me. One is in Auderghem and serves residents of four communes: Auderghem, Ixelles, Etterbeek and Watermael-Boitsfort. Another, in Woluwe-Saint-Pierre, is open to residents of both Ws: Woluwe-Saint-Pierre and Woluwe-Saint-Lambert.

The remaining four — Buda in Neder-Over-Heembeek, Demets in Anderlecht, and Sud and Humanité in Forest — can be used by anyone domiciled in the Brussels region. Take your ID card or proof of residence — to be checked, not thrown away — and sort everything before you arrive.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz is in Dublin today but the frustration and anger within his party back home will be weighing on his mind.

London: After the good vibes and TikToks, Andy Burnham is moving on to the long-term policy pains set to dominate the rest of this week.

Paris: Emmanuel Macron's move to ban social media for under-15s is back on the agenda, with Big Tech descending on the Elysée Palace for high-level meetings .

Washington PM: Donald Trump is in Michigan to tout his push to revive domestic manufacturing — an opportunity to amp up his midterm messaging on the economy .

AGENDA

— Irish Prime Minister Micheál Martin receives German Chancellor Friedrich Merz in Dublin, with a press conference following.

— Fisheries Commissioner Costas Kadios participates in the informal meeting of fisheries ministers in Cork, Ireland.

— Commission Executive Vice President Raffaele Fitto attends the launch of the Italian Presidency of the EU Strategy for the Adriatic and Ionian Region.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Mario Mantovani; former Commission Vice President Margaritis Schinas; former Greek PM Alexis Tsipras; former MEP Kazimierz Michał Ujazdowski; European Commission's Siobhan McGarry; Dirk Jacobs of FoodDrinkEurope; Lenovo's Ana Gradinaru; Kumquat's Bruno Selun; Thai King Maha Vajiralongkorn; European Public Service Union's Adam Rogalewski and Chloe Kenny.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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